



Plants for sun-baked areas

Choices are limited for free-draining soils that retain few plant nutrients, yet some highly prized species have adapted to grow well in them.

Most sun-loving wildflowers abhor rich soil, and many cultivated plants, such as hollyhock and cosmos, will also thrive in free-draining, sun-baked conditions. As well as the plants listed here, others cope with poor soils once they are established, so take a look at the selection for sandy soils too (see pp.44–51), and provide water and some fertilizer for the first few seasons after planting. One benefit of well-drained soils is that plants that suffer in cold, wet soils over winter, such as perennial wallflower and fleshy-leaved succulents, are more likely to survive in dry conditions.



SHRUB SMALL

Caryopteris x clandonensis

BLUEBEARD This bushy deciduous shrub thrives in free-draining soils. It forms clumps of gray-green lance-shaped leaves and dense clusters of small purplish blue flowers from late summer to fall. 'Worcester Gold' (above) has contrasting golden foliage.

†3ft (1m) ↔ 5ft (1.5m)

☀️ Z6–9



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Cosmos sulphureus

SULPHUR COSMOS Hailing from scrublands, this upright bushy annual bears a wealth of bowl-shaped, yellow, orange, or scarlet semidouble flowers all summer. Its feathery green leaves are attractive, too. It is easy to grow from seed in spring. Can be weedy.

†16in (40cm) ↔ 8in (20cm)

☀️ N



PERENNIAL LARGE

Achillea filipendulina

YARROW Perfect for dry soil and full sun, this clump-forming perennial has finely cut gray-green leaves and sturdy stems punctuated with flat-topped golden-yellow flower heads in summer. 'Gold Plate' (above) is a tall variety growing up to 5ft (1.6m).

†4ft (1.2m) ↔ 24in (60cm)

☀️ Z3–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

Alcea rosea

HOLLYHOCK This upright perennial may self-seed in cracks and dry, dusty soils. Its rounded leaves are joined by white, yellow pink, or red cup-shaped flowers that attract bees and butterflies from mid- to late summer. Considered invasive in many areas.

†6ft (2m) ↔ 24in (60cm)

☀️ Z3–9



BULB SMALL

Crocus chrysanthus

CROCUS Plant this tiny perennial bulb in fall in a sunny spot in free-draining soil, where its cup-shaped blooms with dark green linear leaves appear in early spring. Varieties include 'Gypsy Girl' (above) with purple-striped yellow flowers.

†3in (7cm)

☀️ Z3–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Delosperma nubigenum

ICE PLANT This ground-hugging evergreen perennial, perfect for sun-baked soils, produces mats of triangular, succulent green leaves and lemon-yellow daisy-like flowers in summer. Use it to edge a bed; it may need frost protection in cold areas.

†2in (5cm) ↔ 20in (50cm)

☀️ Z6–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Dianthus alpinus

ALPINE PINK Plant this mat-forming evergreen perennial in raised beds or at the front of a dry bed. Its gray-green foliage is joined in summer by white or pink blooms held on short stems. 'Joan's Blood' (above) has deep crimson solitary blooms.

†3in (8cm) ↔ 4in (10cm)

☀️ Z3–8



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Dorotheanthus bellidiformis

LIVINGSTON DAISY Grow this low-growing annual to edge the front of a sun-baked bed, where it will thrive. It produces small fleshy leaves and red, pink, orange, and white daisy-like summer flowers, which open in sun, closing again in the evenings.

†6in (15cm) ↔ 12in (30cm)

☀️



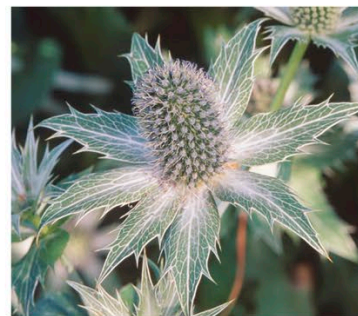
ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Echium vulgare

VIPER'S BUGLOSS A bristly biennial with a basal rosette of lance-shaped leaves. In early summer, it produces slender spikes of vivid violet-blue bell-shaped blooms. This drought-tolerant plant is ideal for wildlife gardens and sun-baked beds.

†24in (60cm) ↔ 12in (30cm)

☀️ Z3–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Eryngium maritimum

SEA HOLLY Found growing on exposed rocky coastal sites, this upright perennial has prickly, white-veined, blue-green basal leaves. Thimblelike metallic blue blooms with spiny collars appear on branched stems from early summer to early fall.

†20in (50cm) ↔ 18in (45cm)

☀️ Z5–9